

Ambition Mapping: Where the Class Stands, and Where It Is Headed

Information & Interaction Design — triangle sketches of 31 August 2026

Analysis of 28 student submissions

2 September 2026

Data and method

Each student sketched a triangle whose vertices are the course’s three reference disciplines — **psychology**, **graphics** (visual design), and **coding** — and placed two marks inside it: where their skills sit *now* and where they want to be in the *future*, joined by an arrow. All 28 submissions were read visually and each mark was converted to an approximate barycentric weighting over the three vertices (visual estimates, roughly ± 10 points). Nineteen students used the canonical vertex set (one substituted the synonym “design” for graphics); these are plotted together in Figure 1. The remaining nine redrew the triangle around other vertices (informatics, business, leadership, marketing, career roles) and are summarized separately in Table 2, since their positions are not commensurable with the shared frame.

Findings

1. The dominant motion is a flow toward psychology, not a collapse to the center. Fifteen of the 19 plotted students gain psychology weight (median gain ≈ 15 points); the class mean moves from (34, 33, 33) — statistically indistinguishable from the perfectly balanced centroid — to (41, 30, 29), i.e. +7.5 psychology, −3.1 graphics, −4.4 coding. Average distance from the centroid barely changes (only 9 of 19 end *closer* to it), so the class is not simply “converging on balance”: it is rotating its collective weight toward the human-understanding vertex while keeping graphics and coding as a retained base. Several students said this outright, e.g. “I want to ... better understand the psychology behind them” (Brunell).

2. Coding is a starting asset, almost never a destination. Most *now* marks sit in the lower half of the triangle, on or near the graphics–coding edge — consistent with the cohort’s self-described identities (informatics, CS, data, UX-engineering students). Only two students (Kumar, L. Nguyen) move *toward* coding, and both frame it as rounding out a design-heavy profile rather than specializing.

3. Two dramatic counter-flows toward graphics. Villarreal and J. Torres are the only students whose futures are *more* specialized than their present: both start high under the psychology vertex and traverse nearly the full psychology–graphics edge, landing just above the graphics vertex (“ambition: psych $\rightarrow$ graphics”; “informatics student $\rightarrow$ UX researcher”). They are the visually largest displacements in the figure.

4. The reframed triangles tell the complementary story: apex $\rightarrow$ center. Among the nine students who replaced the canonical vertices (Table 2), the recurring pattern is a *now* placed directly under the vertex naming their current major or role (informatics, business, data science) and a *future* at the balanced center — an explicit “I am one-dimensional today and want to diversify.” Substituted vertices are revealing in themselves: students most often swapped *psychology* out for their home discipline, suggesting the human vertex is the least-owned identity coming into the course.

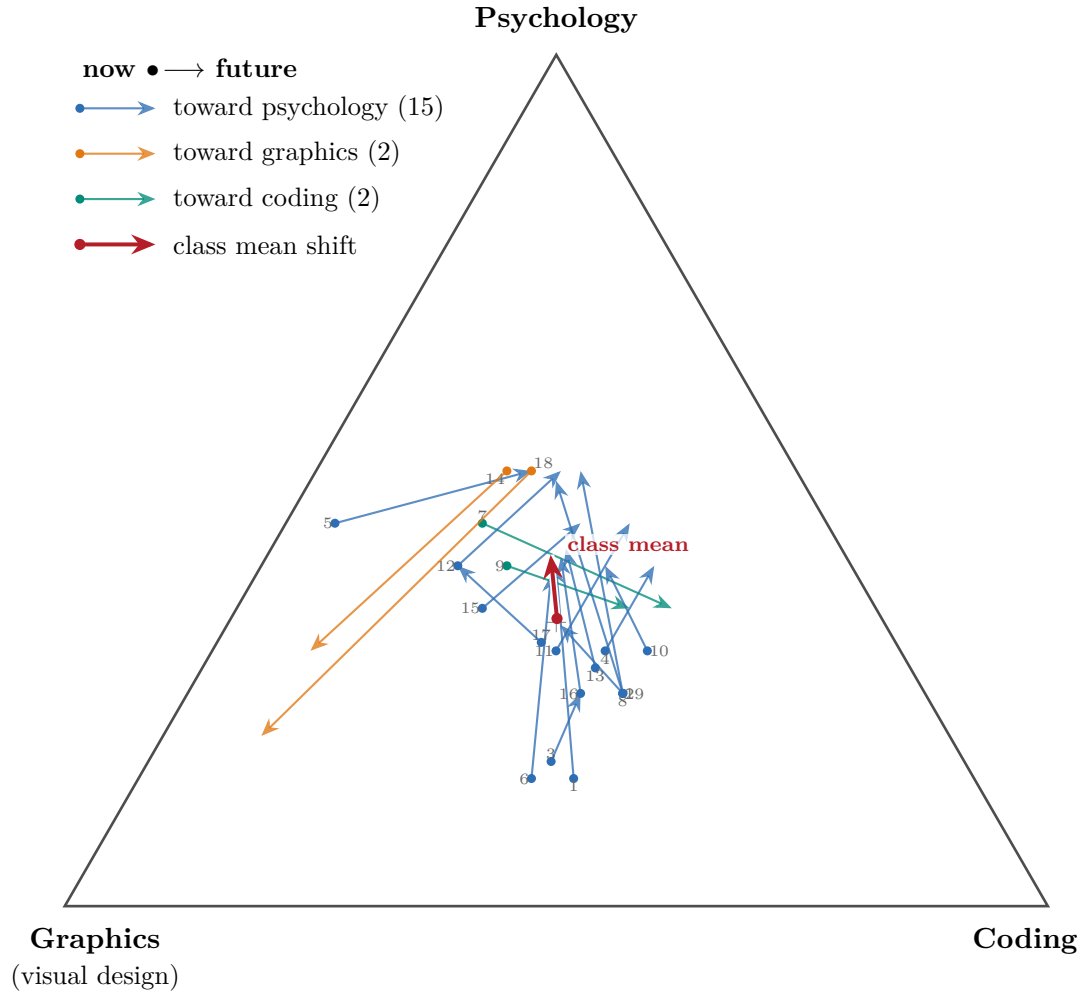


Figure 1: All 19 canonical-frame self-placements on one triangle. Each dot is a student's *now*; the arrowhead is their *future*. Numbers key to Table 1. The gray cross marks the centroid (equal thirds); note the class-mean *now* sits almost exactly on it. Arrows are colored by the vertex whose weight the student gains most. Positions are visual estimates from hand-drawn sketches (± 10 points); two pairs of coincident *now* points (1/3 and 11/17) were nudged apart minimally for legibility.

5. Ambitions cluster on hybrid product roles. Of the 24 students who wrote an ambition caption, the named destinations are overwhelmingly generalist: **product designer** (≈ 7 , including “healthcare product designer”), **UX designer/researcher** (≈ 5), **product manager** (3), then one each of product marketer, technical sales, data engineer/analyst, app designer, mobile-app design, and “AI societal-impacts researcher.” The modal narrative arc, stated almost verbatim by nine students, is “*informatics student* $\rightarrow$ *product/UX designer*.”

6. Process observations. Format was highly uniform (two circled marks, one arrow, monochrome pen/pencil, dated 8/31, an “ambition:” caption; only one submission carried no written note). At least five sketches show erased and repositioned marks — students visibly deliberated over where they stand. One outlier (Low) mapped seven career roles across a communication/marketing/tech triangle instead of two points, the most elaborated submission in the set.

Table 1: Canonical-frame students plotted in Figure 1. Weights are visual estimates of (psychology, graphics, coding) in percent.

#	Student	Now (p, g, c)	Future (p, g, c)	Stated ambition
1	Brunell, Erika	(15, 40, 45)	(40, 30, 30)	more graphics + the psychology behind them
2	Chen, Yu-Hsin	(25, 25, 50)	(33, 33, 34)	CS student $\rightarrow$ product designer
3	Fernandez, Andres	(15, 40, 45)	(25, 35, 40)	human-centered DS $\rightarrow$ data engineer/analyst
4	Guizar, Angelina	(30, 30, 40)	(40, 20, 40)	informatics $\rightarrow$ mobile app design/developer
5	Kamle, Prachiti	(45, 50, 5)	(75, 15, 10)	UX designer $\rightarrow$ UI/UX researcher
6	Kim, Alex	(15, 45, 40)	(40, 30, 30)	UX student $\rightarrow$ design
7	Kumar, Nikitha	(45, 35, 20)	(35, 15, 50)	UX $\rightarrow$ product designer
8	Melendez Gonzalez, Isabella	(25, 30, 45)	(50, 25, 25)	informatics $\rightarrow$ UX designer
9	Nguyen, Lucas	(40, 35, 25)	(35, 25, 40)	informatics UX $\rightarrow$ UX engineer / product designer
10	Nguyen, Nikki	(30, 25, 45)	(40, 25, 35)	data analytics $\leftrightarrow$ UX designer
11	Robinson, Asher	(30, 35, 35)	(45, 20, 35)	—
12	Sadberry, Lauren	(40, 40, 20)	(55, 22, 23)	UX design/research $\rightarrow$ AI societal-impacts researcher
13	Tchao, Jennie	(28, 32, 40)	(42, 28, 30)	—
14	Torres, Jacklynn	(70, 20, 10)	(30, 60, 10)	informatics $\rightarrow$ UX researcher
15	Tsan, Yasmine	(35, 40, 25)	(45, 25, 30)	UX-design informatics $\rightarrow$ product designer
16	Urquiza Sanchez, Ivonne	(25, 35, 40)	(40, 30, 30)	informatics $\rightarrow$ healthcare product designer
17	Vann, Jacob	(30, 35, 35)	(40, 40, 20)	—
18	Villarreal, Novily	(75, 15, 10)	(20, 70, 10)	“psych $\rightarrow$ graphics”
19	Wu, Ivan	(25, 20, 55)	(55, 20, 25)	UX engineer $\rightarrow$ product / UX designer

Caveats

Positions were read visually from hand-drawn, unscaled sketches; barycentric weights are estimates with roughly ± 10 -point uncertainty, and edge cases (erased and redrawn marks, ambiguous arrowheads) were resolved by the accompanying written captions where available. Counts by movement direction are robust to this uncertainty; individual coordinates are indicative only.

Table 2: The nine students who redrew the triangle around their own vertices. Their placements are not plotted in Figure 1 because the frames are not commensurable.

Student	Their vertices	Movement	Stated ambition
Choday, Nishant	HC data-science student / product manager / software developer	student apex $\rightarrow$ center	balance of all three roles
Datla, Vibha	data science / people-facing / product-centered	DS apex $\rightarrow$ center	data scientist $\rightarrow$ technical sales
Jayanthi, Ashvin	information-data science / graphics / coding	apex $\rightarrow$ center	informatics $\rightarrow$ product manager
Kiran, Nidhi	business / design / coding	business apex $\rightarrow$ center	business $\rightarrow$ product manager
Low, Chloe	communication / marketing / tech-data science	7-role landscape converging bottom-center	advertising + DS student $\rightarrow$ product marketer
Maytesyan, Natalie	psychology / business / coding	coding-lean $\rightarrow$ centroid	software engineer $\rightarrow$ equal balance of all three
Pudu, Pranav	leadership / psych-UI/UX / coding	center $\rightarrow$ leadership apex	—
Smith, Zachary	informatics / graphics / coding	apex $\rightarrow$ center	informatics $\rightarrow$ product designer
Torres, Javier	informatics / graphics / apps	apex $\rightarrow$ slightly toward center	informatics $\rightarrow$ app designer